

Wild Lupine

Lupinus perennis

Sundial Lupine



QUALITIES

An iconic spring prairie forb 1 to 2 feet tall, with palmate leaves of 7 to 11 narrow leaflets that orient throughout the day to track the sun (hence "sundial lupine"). In May and June, vertical racemes of violet-blue pea-like flowers create the legendary wave of color that once defined oak savannas across the upper Midwest. Goes dormant in midsummer, disappearing entirely by August.

CARE

Plant in spring or fall as plug or 1-gallon stock — MN-genotype provenance is essential. Full sun; sandy or well-drained loamy soil. Lupine refuses heavy clay and wet sites. Slow to establish; expect a quiet first year. Hardy to USDA Zone 3. As a legume, fixes nitrogen and conditions soil. Do not amend or fertilize — rich soil makes lupine flop and shortens its life.

HISTORY

Wild lupine is the **only** food plant of the federally endangered Karner Blue butterfly (**Plebejus melissa samuelis**). The Karner Blue was widely abundant across Minnesota's pre-settlement oak savannas. As savannas were converted to agriculture and shaded out by fire suppression, lupine populations crashed and the Karner Blue followed; the butterfly was extirpated from Minnesota in 2008 and listed as endangered nationally. Reintroduction efforts depend on restoring lupine.

REASON TO BE

To plant wild lupine in Minnesota in 2026 is to participate in the restoration of an entire vanished ecosystem. Even one residential planting matters: it feeds bumblebees and a host of native specialist bees that no other species supports. If Karner Blues are ever reintroduced to your area (the work is active in Wisconsin and may extend to MN), your lupine drift will be a stepping-stone. Its ephemeral spring presence — blooming gloriously then fading — teaches a lesson about prairie phenology that nothing else can.